

BREAKING THE POWER OF LACK

TEXT: 3 John 1:2 (NKJV) *“Beloved, I pray that you may prosper in all things and be in health, just as your soul prospers.”*

INTRO: Over the next few weeks we are going to look into the word of God and determine how to break the power of lack.

Anyone ever experienced lack?

For those of you that haven't please allow me to define it for you, so you will know what we are talking about. According to Dictionary.com, lack is, *“The state of being without or not having enough of something.”*

Lack is something that the devil introduced into the world, it did not come from the Lord. When God placed Adam in the garden, he gave him everything he needed and even gave him

dominion. Anytime we experience lack or see it in the world, we can rest assured, the devil is doing that work. The devil is a lie!

I want to set the record straight today – The poorest person in this room is wealthy according to world standards.

According to Globalissues.org “*Almost **half** the world — over three billion people — live on less than \$2.50 a day. At least **80%** of humanity lives on less than \$10 a day. More than **80 percent** of the world's population lives in countries where income differentials are widening.*”

According to Pew Research “*By 2050 four out of ten Christians will be living in poverty.*”

Everywhere poverty is found, one or more of the following factors can be found:

- Foolish leadership...
- Corrupt leadership...
- Lack of education...
- Tragic events as an initiator...

**(Give my testimony as a child and teenager –
Give mine and Susan's testimony as adults)**

Trust me when I say, I know what it is to be in lack – I also have enjoyed having a little more than enough to get by. If I have to choose between poverty and prosperity – I choose prosperity! I know it doesn't make me sound very spiritual but I can tell you that prosperity is far more comfortable.

My upbringing caused me to be very determined to not live my entire life in the vicious cycle of poverty. And I really do mean vicious.

Therefore, I have done everything I can to keep my family from continuing on this path.

The word of God is very clear. 3 John 1:2 (NKJV) ***“Beloved, I pray that you may prosper in all things and be in health, just as your soul prospers.”***

Everything I know about God and His Word points me in the direction of believing He wants us to live beyond the power of Lack.

In spite of this being true, the fact remains that many around this world, and many in this very church are living in lack. Many who are listening to me right now:

- Have more month than money...
- Have more debt than income...
- Have more commitments than ability to meet them...

I believe much of the problem is that many Christians operate under the influence of poverty. How can we know whether or not we are being influenced by a poverty mindset? Here are eight indicators of a mindset of poverty:

- Mal-contentment... When a person who is operating in a poverty mindset gets a job, immediately they start looking for another job. When they get a house, immediately they start looking for another house. When they get a car, immediately they want a better car. When they buy a phone, immediately they start looking for another phone.
- Hording... Those who have a poverty mindset, can't turn loose of anything because they are afraid they will never get anything to replace it. (Depression generation)

- Stinginess... A person who is struggling with a mindset of poverty, is stingy. They do not want to share – They don't want to share anything. Why don't they want to share? Because there is an underground fear that they will not have enough for themselves.
- Worry... Those who battle a poverty mindset, worry about everything. They worry that they do not have anything to worry about. When they have more than enough, they worry that it will not last.
- Materialism... Those who battle a poverty mindset, can never get enough of anything to make them happy. It is not “*money*” that is the root of all evil, it is “*the love of money*” that is the root of all evil. You can have money without loving it, and you can love it without having it. I personally know more people who love it without having it, than I do those who have it and love it. (This may be due to the circles I run in)

- Bragging and Showing off... Those who struggle with a mindset of poverty tend to embellish everything. They brag on and strut everything that comes their way. Their identity is tied up in the things they have.
“Our lives do not consist in the things that we have.”
- Begging and borrowing... Those who have a poverty mentality know how to game the system and would rather have an entitlement than a job. Let me remind us, the first step to slavery is a handout. When a poverty mindset is in motion those who are affected by it fail to pay their rent, their car payment, electric bill, etc... And when something is taken away they become the victim. (People who strip houses when they fail to pay the rent or mortgage, and they are evicted or foreclosed on – Not making our payments is not the fault of the landlord or mortgage company – When folks do this kind of thing, they further complicate their lives – They have to go to court etc...)

- Envy and covetousness... When a poverty mentality is being employed the individual is incessantly envious of the success of others. The Bible tells us to “*mourn with those who mourn*” but it also tells us to “*rejoice with those who rejoice.*” If we are going to break the power of lack, we must learn to celebrate with the have’s - and reach to the have not’s. Rather than becoming envious of the blessings of others we should get close enough to them to see how they positioned themselves to be in the pathway of the blessing. Envy and covetousness blinds the less fortunate to the principles of success of the more fortunate.

I wanted to share these eight indicators so that we could self-assess whether or not one or more of them apply to our lives. If one or more of these indicators is roaming around in our lives, we must repent of it, and set into motion some things that will counteract them. That’s what

this series of messages is about! Over the next couple of weeks, I am going to reveal four principles, that if followed, will most certainly break the back of the power of lack!

ATTITUDE

The ability to transition from poverty to prosperity is driven by our attitude toward money and things.

According to Barna Research:

- 31% of American adults earn \$30K or less annually, before taxes. (2004)
- 34% of American adults earn between \$30K & \$60K annually, before taxes. (2004)
- 15% of American adults earn between \$60K & \$100K annually, before taxes. (2004)
- 6% of Americans earn more than \$100K annually, before taxes. (2004)
- 37% of Americans report that they are in debt. (2000) (Recently we did a survey in a class at our church which revealed that

among the 33 families represented there was in excess of \$1.7 million dollars of junk debt! \$51,515.15 per family! This does not include the house mortgage, the car note, or insurance! America is drowning in a sea of debt!) (Being overextended with debt reveals an attitude toward money and things. The debt attitude is – I have to have things – I will get things no matter what – I want things even if I have to go in debt to get them)

- 33% of born again Christians say it is impossible for them to get ahead in life because of the financial debt they have incurred. (1997)

You can tell where a person's heart is by taking a quick look at their checkbook! Jesus reiterated this in Matthew 6:21 (NKJV) ***“For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also.”***

Someone asked Willie Sutton, the notorious bank robber, why he robbed so many banks. He replied, *"That's where the money is."* Each of us will leave a clear money trail to the location of our most valuable treasure!

George Brazell in his book, *"This is Stewardship"* makes the following statement: *"Stewardship is the sum total of man's attitude and reaction toward the Divine Creator and His creation. God is the owner of all creation, and man is the responsible servant entrusted with, and commissioned to, rightly handle for God His program on earth."* Our attitudes toward money and things, regulate whether we are going to live our lives in poverty or prosperity.

Our attitudes towards these things has to do with who we believe the true owner of such things are. To whom do all our possessions belong? Psalm 24:1 (NKJV) ***"The earth is the LORD's,***

and all its fullness, The world and those who dwell therein."

Once we establish true ownership, breaking the power of lack becomes much easier. God is the owner of all our possessions! In the Bible, a steward was the business manager for a wealthy person. Remember Joseph, who was the steward (Business Manager) over the house of Potiphar?

The person who has developed a proper understanding of ownership knows breaking the power of lack is more of an attitude than an activity!

Those of us who are intent on breaking the power of lack continually ask ourselves the following question. *"What would God have us to do with what He has entrusted to us?"* If this question rules our life then we get it! We are in the beginning stages of breaking the power of lack!

Once we establish the true ownership of our money and things, the generosity debate will be settled in our lives. We will not only tithe but we will be generous, because we realize what we have belongs to the Lord. The money and the things never belonged to us to begin with, therefore it is no skin off our noses to give it away!

CONCLUSION:

(TALK ABOUT WORKING FOR A LIVING VS. GIVING FOR A LIVING) ***“Let him that stole, steal no more. Rather let him labor with his hands that he may have to give.”***

A proper attitude toward money and things lands a crushing blow on the indicators of a mindset of poverty:

- Malcontent...
- Hoarding...
- Stinginess...

- Worry...
- Materialism...
- Bragging and showing off...
- Begging and borrowing...
- Envy and covetousness...

OBEDIENCE

Leviticus 27:30-34 (NLT) ***"A tenth of the produce of the land, whether grain or fruit, belongs to the LORD and must be set apart to him as holy. 31 If you want to redeem the LORD's tenth of the fruit or grain, you must pay its value, plus 20 percent. 32 The LORD also owns every tenth animal counted off from your herds and flocks. They are set apart to him as holy. 33 The tenth animal must not be selected on the basis of whether it is good or bad, and no substitutions will be allowed. If any exchange is in fact made, then both the original animal and the substituted one will be***

*considered holy and cannot be redeemed.” 34
These are the commands that the LORD gave to
the Israelites through Moses on Mount Sinai.”
Malachi 3:10 (KJV) "Bring all the tithes into
the storehouse..."*

(LAST WEEK WAS ABOUT ATTITUDE
AND OWNERSHIP – THIS WEEK WE ARE
GOING TO TALK ABOUT TRUST)

It would be literally impossible for a rational person to read these two Scriptures and conclude that tithing is anything other than a commandment! Tithing is not a suggestion for a Christian; it is a commandment to honor God with our finances. This commandment is not because He needs our money, it is because we need to give! There is something about giving and generosity that opens up the heavens.

We need to give the tenth part of our income to God because when we do we are acknowledging that what we have does not belong to us, it belongs to God!

The reason these Scriptures sound so much alike is because they have the same author! This has little to do with Moses or Malachi; the words are being spoken by God through His servants!

The first rule of stewardship is to seek God first. The person who resists His commands is not seeking Him first, they have an ulterior motive.

When a person is not a tither, his resources are invested in the following way; Luke 12:16-19 (NKJV) *"Then He spoke a parable to them, saying: ***'The ground of a certain rich man yielded plentifully.17 'And he thought within himself, saying, 'What shall I do, since I have no room to store my crops?'***18 ***'So he said, 'I will do this: I will pull down my barns and build greater, and there I will store all my crops and my goods.19 'And I will say to my soul, 'Soul, you have many goods laid up for many years; take your ease; eat, drink, and be merry.'***"* Please understand; there is nothing

wrong with prosperity. We would all probably like to be a little more prosperous. There is nothing wrong with bumper crops and bigger barns; the point is this man did not consider God in his wealth, he made all his decisions solely on what he believed was best for him.

Listen to how Jesus finishes this parable...

Luke 12:20-21 (NKJV) ***“But God said to him, ‘Fool! This night your soul will be required of you; then whose will those things be which you have provided?’²¹ “So is he who lays up treasure for himself, and is not rich toward God.”***

We have established that we are stewards, God's business managers; stewards are not required to be successful, they are required to be faithful! 1 Corinthians 4:2 (NKJV) ***“Moreover it is required in stewards that one be found faithful.”***

When we tithe we not only acknowledge that everything we have belongs to God, but we begin to walk in obedience to His command, thus placing ourselves, and our families in the pathway of a blessing. Listen to the words of Jesus with regard to tithing, Matthew 23:23 (CEV) ***"You Pharisees and teachers are show-offs, and you're in for trouble! You give God a tenth of the spices from your garden, such as mint, dill, and cumin. Yet you neglect the more important matters of the Law, such as justice, mercy, and faithfulness. These are the important things you should have done, though you should not have left the others undone either."*** If you are one of those people who are hung up on tithing being an Old Testament principle, Jesus himself says here in the New Testament that the Pharisees should be paying their tithes.

Tithing fulfills a direct commandment of the Lord. We should tithe because we have been commanded to do so and it is our hearts desire

to walk in obedience. When we walk in obedience we begin to break the power of lack!

The government of God and man is predicated upon the principle of each person adhering to the laws set forth by God and man. If the law is not followed judgment must be enacted upon the offender. If judgment is not enacted upon the offender eventually anarchy will set in and everyone will be a law unto themselves and will do that which is right in their own eyes!

Everyone in this place is aware that for a society to function properly there must be laws and penalties for breaking those laws.

If this were not true, you would not be safe anywhere.

As a society crumbles, its laws and penalties become more and more lax. America is headed into a downward spiral for this very reason.

Those who intentionally break laws, whether they are of God or man, are rebellious, thus they become rebels!

From one end of the Bible to the other, obedience is a trait that is heralded as extremely important in the life of the believer. Adam and Eve got into trouble in Genesis for a lack of obedience. It is clear in Revelation 21:8 that the disobedient will be cast into the lake of fire.

Listen to what the Prophet Isaiah has to say on the subject of obedience and lack of it. Isaiah 1:19-20 (NKJV) ***"If you are willing and obedient, You shall eat the good of the land; 20 But if you refuse and rebel, You shall be devoured by the sword"; For the mouth of the LORD has spoken."*** What are the principles taught here?

- To receive what we need from the Lord we must be willing and obedient ***"You shall eat the good of the land..."***

- If we refuse to do what God has commanded us to do we will be devoured by the enemy
"If you refuse and rebel, You shall be devoured by the sword..."
- Isaiah did not speak this, God spoke it *"For the mouth of the LORD has spoken..."*

God desires the same thing from His children as I desire from mine, obedience! To fail to tithe is to be a disobedient child! To be a disobedient child is to be a rebel.

We should tithe in an effort of walking in obedience to God, and therefore breaking the power of lack over our lives and family lines.

TRUST

Tithing does not require trust and therefore does not necessarily bring with it the blessing of multiplication. Tithing places the believer in a position of releasing the Lord to rebuke the devourer for our sakes. Tithing does not break

the spirit of mammon on the money; the believer should bind the spirit of mammon over their income and pronounce the blessing of the Lord upon it.

First-fruit requires trust and enacts the blessing of multiplication upon our resources. If I give the first of what I have believing for at least nine more that requires trust – Trust is a big deal to God)

Proverbs 3:5-6 (NKJV) ***“Trust in the LORD with all your heart, And lean not on your own understanding;⁶ In all your ways acknowledge Him, And He shall direct your paths.”***

- ***“Trust”*** means, bold, confident, careless...
- ***“Ways”*** means, life, mode of acting...
- ***“Direct”*** means, pleasant, prosperous, good...

- ***“Path”*** means, well-trodden road, your caravan or your troop...

Let me paraphrase this – ***“Be bold, confident and careless when it comes to the things of the Lord by refusing to lean on your own understanding. Acknowledge God first with the way you live your life and He will make the traveling path of your troop or caravan, pleasant, prosperous, and good.”***

CONCLUSION:

If we desire to have our way made prosperous by breaking the power of lack we must first learn to trust the Lord.

(ASK EVERYONE WHO HAS A \$5 BILL OR HIGHER TO COME FORWARD)

We must be willing to give up what we have in our hand to get what He has in His! We cannot

expect to keep what we have in our hand and also get what He has in His!

GENEROSITY

Deuteronomy 26:1-2,13-14 (NKJV) *“And it shall be, when you come into the land which the LORD your God is giving you as an inheritance, and you possess it and dwell in it,² “that you shall take some of the first of all the produce of the ground, which you shall bring from your land that the LORD your God is giving you, and put it in a basket and go to the place where the LORD your God chooses to make His name abide.¹³ “then you shall say before the LORD your God: ‘I have removed the holy tithe from my house, and also have given them to the Levite, the stranger, the fatherless, and the widow, according to all Your commandments which You have commanded me; I have not transgressed Your commandments, nor have I forgotten them.¹⁴ ‘I have not eaten any of it when in mourning,*

nor have I removed any of it for an unclean use, nor given any of it for the dead. I have obeyed the voice of the LORD my God, and have done according to all that You have commanded me.”

(LAST TWO WEEKS – ATTITUDES AND OWNERSHIP – OBEDIENCE – TRUST – THIS WEEK WE ARE GOING TO TALK ABOUT GENEROSITY)

Since I am dealing with the subject of generosity I want to make sure I am very clear; I in no way want to leave the impression that when we give we are guaranteed great riches. What I am saying, however, is that when we get our attitude right in the giving department, we set ourselves up to be blessed in so many ways that it would deplete the space on my hard drive to tell you how many avenues of blessing the lord could choose while blessing us.

The power of lack cannot be broken without enacting generosity. We cannot talk about giving without talking about stewardship. We are stewards for God; we are his business managers; everything we have belongs to the Lord. When we realize who owns it all, it is not nearly as difficult to follow His will in giving. If I give it all away at His direction, it is alright because there is more where that came from. (Larissa – *“It’s ok dad, there’s more where that came from.”*)

I am Gods steward, what I have belongs to Him, He can direct it as He pleases, and when He asks for it all I must remember *“It’s OK Dad, there’s more where that came from.”*

When it comes to giving, God has given us stewardship responsibilities over our lives. While we have stewardship responsibilities, we

must not touch anything He has placed as off limits for us. We have established that the tithe belongs to the lord and the person who touches the tithe is doing exactly what Adam and Eve did in the garden.

Generosity, not tithing, is the defining test of all would-be-stewards and is essential in breaking the power of lack. This is also the only area in which we are admonished to test God. Malachi 3:10 (NKJV) ***“Bring all the tithes into the storehouse, That there may be food in My house, And try Me now in this,” Says the LORD of hosts, “If I will not open for you the windows of heaven And pour out for you such blessing That there will not be room enough to receive it.”***

Matthew 25:29 (NLT) ***“To those who use well what they are given, even more will be given, and they will have an abundance. But from those who are unfaithful, even what little they***

have will be taken away.” (BRING 3 PEOPLE UP TO DO TRIP ILLUSTRATION)

Generosity:

- Is not a grim duty to be performed by the Christian...
- Is not a dry religious exercise which kills the Spirit of a service...
- Is not punishment intended to cost the believer hard earned cash...

It is a wonderful opportunity to invest in the kingdom of God and in doing so; it brings unbelievable benefits to the generous person. Not to mention the protection that is provided with regard to the devourer.

Is there anyone here who expects to benefit from the stock market without investing in it? Does anyone expect to attend the stockholders

meeting of a corporation and receive benefits from it unless they own stock in the company? The power of lack gets broken for those who have Kingdom buy in.

An essential key to breaking the power of lack is, generosity! If we cannot pass the generosity test with a good attitude, we can forget being in possession of the many other blessings and gifts of God. Proverbs 11:24 (NKJV) ***“There is one who scatters, yet increases more; And there is one who withholds more than is right, But it leads to poverty.”*** My personal paraphrase: ***“The path of the generous leads to prosperity; The path of the stingy leads to poverty.”*** I do not know one wealthy person who got there without making others wealthy. People criticize Sam Walton and Wal-Mart, but I personally know several people who went to work for them early on and participated in the profit sharing program who retired from Wal-Mart as millionaires.

Tithing is all about addition but generosity is the first step toward multiplication

Webster defines multiplication in the following way: *“A method used to find the result of adding a specified quantity repeatedly a specific number of times.”*

The Bible is full of instances of the miracle of multiplication:

- The strength of Israelite soldiers was multiplied on many occasions when they were hopelessly outnumbered...
- The meal and oil of the widow and her son was multiplied...
- The multiplication of a little boy's lunch...

I want us to zero in on this miracle of multiplication here in Luke 9 which outlines how Jesus took a meal of fish and chips from

Long John Silvers and fed a multitude of people.

Jesus blessed the little boys lunch and told the disciples to give it away! Can you imagine what Peter, or for that part, Thomas, must have been thinking as they walked into the crowd with a half a handful of fish and bread and 5,000 men to feed? I would give anything to be able to record the thoughts of the disciples...

- Peter – Walking on water is one thing, but this is ridiculous...
- Thomas – I doubt if this is going to work...
- John – I love Jesus but we've never done it like this before...
- Andrew – How is this going to work, there are more people than there is lunch...
- Luke – My medical education tells me there is not enough here to satisfy the hunger of this crowd...

- Judas – All He is going to do is stir up these hungry folks and I will have to bankrupt the treasury to settle them down...
- James – I know He has performed a lot of miracles but I think He has over loaded himself this time...

The thing that Jesus knew that the disciples were not aware of was the key of multiplication! Jesus may have fed upwards of 20,000 people that day with five biscuits and two pieces of fish - And then took up twelve baskets of fragments!!! One for each disciple!

Tithing is all about addition and brings about:

- Compliance...
- The breaking of the curse...
- The addition of resources...

Going from addition to multiplication is where I believe God wants to take us, and where most of us need to go. Making this transition is not possible without two things:

- Generosity...
- First-Fruits... (EXPLAIN THIS)

We must remember, there will never be multiplication without generosity! There are at least three things one must do in order to see the miracle of multiplication working in one's life.

KEY #1:

A thing must be blessed before it can multiply! Jesus blessed the fish and bread before he distributed it to the multitudes. If we desire to see the miracle of multiplication occur in our finances we must first bless them. How do we bless them? Pray over them dedicating the first-fruit to God, then following through to complete our part of the covenant. Romans 11:16 (NKJV)

“For if the first-fruit is holy, the lump is also holy; and if the root is holy, so are the branches.” What this Scripture does not say is almost as important as what it does say. If the first-fruit is misapplied everything that follows after it is also cursed.

We should pray over all resources that flow into our hands, portfolio's and bank accounts. We should break the power of mammon and speak a spirit of multiplication over everything that comes into our possession.

There are many sweet well-intentioned Christians who have never personally witnessed the miracle of multiplication where their resources are concerned. It is not that they are bad people; they have just never understood the principle of blessing their finances and doing the first-fruits.

KEY #2:

Only what is given away can multiply! The disciples were handling blessed bread which now had the power of multiplication on it! It had been blessed so it had the potential for multiplication! If the disciples had decided to eat the meal themselves, it would not have been enough for twelve people. But when they started to give it away they witnessed the miracle of multiplication. If they had used the lunch for themselves they would have had a couple of bites each, instead they witnessed a tremendous miracle and had full stomachs and twelve baskets of leftovers!

Even though the food was blessed it had to be given away in order for it to multiply. I am here to remind us today that only what we give away can be multiplied! If we need a financial blessing we must find a way to sow a financial seed that is proportionate to what we need to receive!

KEY #3:

First-fruit. First-fruit embodies the principle of generosity.

Tithing is not giving - It is returning what belongs to God to begin with. (DARLENE LANIER – “*Pastor, we can’t pay our tithe, all we can do is return them. They never belonged to us.*”) Tithing makes one compliant, stops the curse, and initiates the process of addition. The miracle of multiplication occurs when we first fruit, and give generously above the tithe.

This is precisely what Harvest Sunday is all about. We are asking each of you to tithe today, and normally we ask you to tithe on what you want to be making at this time next year. But this year I am asking you to do two things:

- 100% of the people tithing today...

- Above your tithe I want you to give 1% of what you want to reduce your debt for the coming 12 months... (I sincerely believe the Lord spoke this to me at 7:35 Friday morning, December 30th)

If you are sitting there saying, “*This is just a gimmick to get me to give*” please do not participate, because it is not going to work for you. All giving must be with a certain expectation and mixed with faith.

CONCLUSION:

Let me conclude with two Bible references. The prophet Haggai points to the problem of lack among church going tithe payers. The problem was the lack of generosity toward the house of God. Listen to this: Haggai 1:1-11 (NKJV)

“In the second year of King Darius, in the sixth month, on the first day of the month, the word of the LORD came by Haggai the prophet

to Zerubbabel the son of Shealtiel, governor of Judah, and to Joshua the son of Jehozadak, the high priest, saying, ² “Thus speaks the LORD of hosts, saying: ‘This people says, “The time has not come, the time that the LORD’s house should be built.” ’ ” ³ Then the word of the Lord came by Haggai the prophet, saying, ⁴ “Is it time for you yourselves to dwell in your paneled houses, and this temple to lie in ruins?” ⁵ Now therefore, thus says the LORD of hosts: “Consider your ways!” ⁶ “You have sown much, and bring in little; You eat, but do not have enough; You drink, but you are not filled with drink; You clothe yourselves, but no one is warm; And he who earns wages, Earns wages to put into a bag with holes.” ⁷ Thus says the LORD of hosts: “Consider your ways!” ⁸ Go up to the mountains and bring wood and build the temple, that I may take pleasure in it and be glorified,” says the LORD. ⁹ “You looked for much, but indeed it came to little; and when you brought it home, I blew it away. Why?” says

the LORD of hosts. “Because of My house that is in ruins, while every one of you runs to his own house.”¹⁰ Therefore the heavens above you withhold the dew, and the earth withholds its fruit.¹¹ For I called for a drought on the land and the mountains, on the grain and the new wine and the oil, on whatever the ground brings forth, on men and livestock, and on all the labor of your hands.”

Some people say, “We use our tithe to give to needy people.” “We support other ministries with our tithe.” “We give our tithe to missions.” The same people would never buy their groceries at Kroger and go to price saver to pay for them. They wouldn’t think of filling up at Exxon and driving down to Valero to pay for their fuel. The Bible is clear about this – **“Bring ALL the tithe into the STOREHOUSE.”** The storehouse is the local church you attend and NOTHING else.

One more scripture. King Hezekiah witnessed the connection between generosity and multiplication when he required the people to tithe of the first-fruit and the first-born. 2 Chronicles 31:4-10 (NLT) *“In addition, **he required the people in Jerusalem to bring the prescribed portion of their income to the priests and Levites, so they could devote themselves fully to the law of the LORD. 5 The people responded immediately and generously with the first of their crops and grain, new wine, olive oil, honey, and all the produce of their fields. They brought a tithe of all they owned. 6 The people who had moved to Judah from Israel, and the people of Judah themselves, brought in the tithes of their cattle and sheep and a tithe of the things that had been dedicated to the LORD their God, and they piled them up in great heaps. 7 The first of these tithes was brought in late spring, and the heaps continued to grow until early autumn. 8 When Hezekiah and his officials came and saw these huge piles, they thanked the LORD and***

his people Israel! 9 “Where did all this come from?” Hezekiah asked the priests and Levites.10 And Azariah the high priest, from the family of Zadok, replied, “Since the people began bringing their gifts to the LORD’s Temple, we have had enough to eat and plenty to spare, for the LORD has blessed his people.”